The test was all about applying skills to solve basic problems. I suddenly started to believe in my own ability to do exactly that. And what better time for self-introspection than a life-changing interview? Without fretting further, I began my test. It was time-based—ideally thirty seconds for each question. I raced against time and finished the test two minutes early and looked up. At a desk adjacent to mine, Hema's head was buried in the answer sheet but she, too, managed to finish in time. We sighed simultaneously as the examiner collected our answer sheets. Results were awaited eagerly.

The sun had crawled down the western sky as all the candidates waited in line outside the examination hall. There was a mild chill in the evening wind, which carried to us the faint aroma of dinner being cooked in the mess. Some girls passionately discussed the questions and their probable answers. Hema, however, was busy guessing the dinner menu with another girl, not really fretting like most of us. Restlessness threatened to get the better of me but I stood there as quietly as I could. As we heard Sqn Ldr Yadav's approaching footsteps, my heart began to thud in my chest. He held a file in his hand; inside it were the results. Multiple thoughts assaulted my mind at once. It must have been the same for all of us. We lined up quietly without the need for any instruction on seeing the coordinating officer standing in front of us. I didn't realize my legs were trembling.

'Good evening, candidates,' Sqn Ldr Yadav started to speak, 'I must tell you that all of you performed well, so it wasn't easy for us to make the selection.' I could hardly breathe as he continued. 'In this test, all of you are winners, but some of you have performed exceptionally well to meet our selection criteria. Those chest numbers that I will now announce are requested to please come and stand to my left.' And then he began calling out the numbers. 'Chest numbers 238, 236, 224, 208, 199, 197, 183 . . .' *God! Why did he have to start backwards*? I started to pick at my lower lip as I waited. After about a minute, I found myself standing in a bigger group as a smaller group continued to assemble to his left. *These had to be the ones who had made it through the screening*. As the chest numbers reached the double digits, I closed my eyes and saw a picture come to life in the